

The professional with terror as
last warrior, guided by gods and

Pronoun OF EVIL

By S. Prasannarajan

At first glance, there is nothing that makes him distinctive in the bustling anonymity of a metropolitan street. Nothing except that gun of disproportionate size—an AK-47—he carries in his right hand. Everything else—grey cargos, faux Versace, overstuffed rucksack and floppy hair—adds to the generic drabness of a backpacker, though his movement is not dictated by a well-travelled Lonely Planet but the Book of Higher Directions. He is not a grainy image confined to the front pages or the small screens any longer; he has migrated to the consciousness of a nation savaged. He is the lone survivor of the gang of 10 that, in the span of 60 hours that may have seemed longer than eternity to those who are condemned to mourn, turned the emblematic city of corporate aspiration and cosmopolitan attitude into the scalded soul of India. He is the living residue of the Evil that spreads from streets to railway station, from hotel rooms to Jewish quarters, from the frozen gaze of the dead to the seared sighs of the living, leaving behind a wreckage of fear and anger, grief and dread. Ajmal Amir Kasab is his name. We have seen